

# Saga of Saint Thorlak

Bishops' Sagas

Norse Sagas

*translated by Frederick York, 1905*

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## THE STORY OF BISHOP THORLAC

1

1. 1. IN the days when pope Anacletus [II] ruled God's Christendom, and Magnus Sigurd's son and Harold Gille[-christ] were kings of Norway, there was born in a part of Iceland that is called Fleet- lithe, Thor-lac the holy, at the farm that is called Lithe-end, in the year when bishop Thor-lac Runolfs son died [1133].

2

2. Their names were the same, not because he was called after bishop Thor-lac, but rather because He, that knoweth and governeth all things, wished to do honour withal to the former bishop Thor-lac, that his name might be ever loved and worshipped by all them that have since been permitted to hear and know the worth of the blessed bishop Thor- lac. And Almighty God has vouchsafed to the blessed bishop's name that honour, which Solomon the Sage said aforetime that 'a good name is better than much riches' [Prov xxii. 1], and that was truly a good name then, since it was hallowed by holy baptism and afterwards blessed by the bishoply honour. The proverb is proved true that 'a wise man's words will come to pass,' for this name hath now become better than much gold to them that call on him in their need. And this which holy writ saith in another place, that 'better is a good name than precious ointment' [Eccles vulg vii. 2], hath come true no whit less in this matter, inasmuch as it is now often proven by trial that sickness is oftentimes speedily cured by calling upon his name, that could never be healed before by any ointment or any of the medicines that had been taken or tried before.

3

2. 1. THE father of Thor-lac was Thor-hall, and his mother Halla. They were well thought of and of good parts. He was a merchantman before he set up housekeeping, and she was a thrifty and thoughtful woman. They were both of good family, and come of gentle kin. And it is now

made manifest that God hath fairly fulfilled to us that which he promised by the mouth of David the prophet, that ‘the generation of the righteous shall be blessed’ [Ps vulg cxi. 2], and it is manifest that this hath now been fairly fulfilled and shown forth in the life of the blessed bishop Thor-lac. The nearest kinsfolk of Thor-lac were upright and honest of life; of calls upon them they had many, but of means not enough. Thor-lac was yet young in years when they broke up their household, his father and mother.

4

2. He was unlike most young men in bringing up, gentle and genial in all things, obedient and obliging to every one, silent and self-restrained in all his ways, clever and quick at learning even in his young years. He got the psalter by heart before the household of his father and mother were parted; but he had little other book-learning at first, nevertheless he was already so thoughtful in his young years that many wise men noticed it. But although he had not much learning as a child, yet in all his ways it looked as if he had well-nigh learnt all that which might make him a better man than before. He never set his mind on play or vain pleasures, he was easy and even-tempered, and early made it manifest in his conversation that he meant to take to heart those wholesome admonitions which David teacheth in the psalter, that a man should ‘turn from evil and do good, seek peace, and pursue it’ [Ps vulg xxxiii. 15].

5

3. 1. WHEN his mother saw from his wisdom, by God’s providence, how goodly a clerk Thor-lac might become through his good conversation, if only he could get on with his learning, then his mother and he betook themselves to the highest chief-place in Ord under the hands of priest Eyjolf, Sæmund’s son, who had both great chiefship and good learning, goodness and wisdom in greater measure than most other men. And we have heard the blessed Thor-lac bear this witness of him — that he had hardly ever found a man so good as he was, and he made it to be seen afterwards that he would not let those wholesome

admonitions with respect to his master pass by him, which the blessed apostle Paul gave to his disciples, when he spake thus to them that heard him, ‘Be ye followers of me, as I am of Christ’ [1 Cor xi. 1]. Insomuch that it often happened when we were praising his good conversation that he would say, ‘those were the ways of Eyjolf Sæmund’s son,’ his foster-father. And he did right in this to give him such honour in his speech, for he had him to thank for this.

6

2. Eyjolf prized Thor-lac most of all his disciples, in all that pertained to clerkship, because he could see from his wisdom and behaviour, as was afterwards proved indeed, that he would surpass them all in these things, as is told later.

7

3. Thor-lac took orders already in his youth, as far as becoming deacon, at the hands of bishop Magnus, and he was fifteen years old when that bishop died. And his orders were taken so soon, because his superiors perceived that he took to heart himself, and observed to the utmost the duties that are required of each order of those that he took. And his learning and his orders did not proceed so fast, but that he forestalled with regular application all those qualities which are needed by those orders. He took to heart, when his learning was lighter and his orders lesser, what bishop Isidore spake, a wise and holy man, that ‘it is profitable both to learn much and to live uprightly, but if a man may not do both, then it is more blessed to live well.’ He also observed, that though the lesser orders rather brought with them lowliness and service than great honour of worldly esteem, yet he kept all those qualities which the smaller offices required after he was raised to the higher degrees of office and honour by [taking] the greater orders.

8

4. It was his habit when he was young in years to keep long hours at his book and to be oftentimes writing, but betweenwhiles he would be at his prayers, and when he had no task in hand, he would learn what his mother could teach him — genealogies and stories of *great* men.

9

4. r. WHEN bishop Magnus was dead for some time there was no bishop at Seal-holt, and there came to be a lack of clerks. It was then men's advice that bishop Beorn should be asked to hold consecrations at the All-moot, and he listened to their prayer, and it was then that Thor-lac was ordained priest and many other clerks with him. But when he was a priest and himself took up the rule and maintenance of the offices [of the church], it was then speedily made manifest how careful and considerate he would be about the hours or services, and all else that was required of him in those orders which he had then taken. Moreover he persevered in the same lowliness of life as before, and took upon himself when the first six months were past a small paid cure or business, and held it somewhile, and it turned out well both as regards money and good report, so that well-nigh every child that was about him loved him. And many good ensamples shown forth have made manifest in the blessed bishop Thor-lac what hath seldom been apparent in many other men, to wit, that he was both young and old at once, young of years and old of wit. Moreover he was clad about with many good qualities, and most of all with them of which David saith that clerks lay in most need, *to wit*, that they should 'be clothed with salvation and judgment' [Ps vulg cxxxii. 9], and this he showed forth afterwards in all his life, so that whatever he had to do went well-nigh never amiss to him, and all they that were about him profited thereby.

10

2. But when this had gone on for some time, and he was now well furnished with money, he was minded to go abroad, for he wished to see the ways of other good men, and he journeyed from Iceland; but there is nothing told of his journeys until he came to Paris, and was there at school as long as he thought needful to get the knowledge which he wished to get there. Thence he came to England, and was at Lincoln, and there he gat moreover great knowledge, and fraught with blessings both to himself and others. And now he had much more good

to put forth in his teaching than he had before, for before he was hardly so well stocked with knowledge as he was now.

11

3. But when he had been six years [c. 1155-61] out of Iceland, then he went back to his kindred and his foster-land, and his kinsmen and his foster-brethren welcomed him back and all his loving friends, but especially his mother and sisters, for they had the greatest longing for him, and they would have suffered most if ought had happened to prevent his return.

12

4. His mother was with him continually after he came back from abroad, and he gave a loving maintenance to his two sisters, Ragn-eid the mother of Paul, who was afterwards bishop after bishop Thor-lac, and Ey-wara, and he had a very long trial by reason of their conversation, which was not after his mind. Nevertheless it all came to a good ending at the last by the mercy of God and by the good mediation of them that were concerned and their own good will.

13

5. He showed the same lowliness or more when he came back from his journeying abroad as he had done before, for he had not brought back with him any show or worldly glory as many other men do who bring back less profit and good fortune from their journey than he had done. It is also the wont of many that they array themselves more finely in weapons and wear when they come home from their journeys, for they get a greater choice of such things abroad than they have had the chance of before. But Thor-lac kept, as the fruits of his journeying, learning and lowliness and many good habits, which he perceived in many good men abroad in his journeys, bishops and other learned and righteous men that came most near to them that lived in that age when God's Christendom first arose and [those by whom it] afterwards waxed great.

14

6. Thor-lac was with his kinsfolk some winters at this time, and had a very good livelihood withal, and many wise men that were about him saw that he was still better endowed in many great and good qualities that were of much moment than he was before he went abroad.

15

7. But after no long time had passed Thor-lac's kinsmen urged him to establish his condition somewhat more firmly than it was then, and especially they wished him to take a wife. They thought that they could see that he was a thrifty man, and a good householder in every way. But God's Christendom had long grown strong and mighty, and the discipline of clerks had increased by reason of restrictions, albeit it was not at that time greatly censured by his superiors if a priest took a widow to wife, though it is now forbidden. And at that time those women in that part of the country who were thought to be the best matches were widows. And Thor-lac, having been egged on to take this counsel, went forth with his kinsmen to the homestead that is named Have, meaning to ask for the hand of the worshipful widow that lived there, and they were received there with a very good will. But when they fell asleep after good cheer that same night, there appeared unto Thor-lac in a dream a man of a noble countenance and seemly raiment, saying, 'What was your errand hither if ye might get it sped?' Thor-lac answered, 'I do not know what it will be,' says he. Then he that appeared unto him in the dream spake. 'I know well,' said he, 'that thou hast in mind to ask to wife the lady here; but do thou not open this matter, because it shall not speed, and there is another bride much higher in store for thee, and thou shalt take none other to thee but her.' And when he had said this he disappeared out of sight; but Thor-lac awoke, and he was now so turned away from the business [he was come on] that he never would ask for any woman's hand. They went away, and he and the lady were good friends all their lives after. But his kinsmen thought it somewhat strange that he should be so changeable in this matter before they knew what had happened, but when they knew it then they were all content. After all this that had happened his

heart was nevertheless not kindled to pride, though it had been manifested to him by God in a vision that he meant him for another end than that which his kinsmen had made out for him and he himself set his mind to: but rather he exercised himself ever the more in lowliness, according to the example of all the best men, that have been ever the more lowly of heart as they have gone up higher in God's sight, according to the wholesome admonition of Almighty God, when he speaketh thus, 'Whosoever is lowly he shall be exalted' [Matt, xxiii. 12], and 'Take example by me, for I am meek and lowly of heart, and ye shall find rest for your souls' [Matt xi. 29]. And when he had not long gone on in this way it was shown forth speedily what he had set his heart upon.

16

5. 1. IN those days there ruled over that homestead in Side that is called Kirkby, a noble clerk whose name was Bearn-hedin, and he was a most worshipful man according to the judgment of all people. He was a wise man and well favoured, free-handed and of very fair speech, lenient, and well learned. And when they came to hear of each other, he and Thor-lac, then each of them yearned for communion with the other; and God, who is wont to grant righteous men their lawful desires, granted it to them, and Thor-lac went over to stay at Kirkby, and he was there six winters together, and they got experience there of what God saith, namely, 'My yoke is easy and my burden is light' [Matt xi. 30].

17

2. And this was both because a strong pair of yoke-fellows were put under the yoke, and also it was a light draught for them, because they took upon themselves to bear well-nigh all the cares of all the people that dwelt in that country-side near them. And they dealt so with them that were in their charge as to take off the heavy burdens that had been laid upon them by offences and evil-speaking against God and good men and by indulgence to the Fiend, and lay upon them instead God's burdens light and lenient with gentle shrifts and easy penances.

They fitted to themselves in a mark-worthy way the names which Almighty God [gives to his servants when he] calls his apostles ‘the light of the world’ [Matt v. 14], inasmuch as they shed a light upon the path of mercy that leadeth to everlasting joy, both by their noble teaching in words and in their precious examples. It might be seen by their daily conversation that that was seldom out of their mind which God spake to his disciples: ‘Let your light so shine before men,’ he said, ‘that they may learn your good works, and glorify your Father which is in heaven’ [Matt v. 16]. And it appeared to them that were with them that there was well-nigh no hour but somewhat good might not be gleaned from them. They were moreover so set together in like behaviour and likemindedness towards good, as Luke saith of God’s apostles, that it might be thought they ‘had but one heart and one soul’ [Acts iv. 32]. So that it spread abroad over the country-side how unlike they were to most men in their behaviour. And now it began to be the common speech of wise men that there would be no more likely quarter to look towards than that where they were, if a man were ever needed for the highest office in Iceland, and this was not misjudged, as was proved later.

18

6. 1. THE owner of the second best homestead in that country, which was named Thick-by, was a man named Thor-kell the son of Geire, a wealthy man of possessions and wise of understanding. And when he began to be stricken somewhat in years, and had no very near kinsman to take the heritage after him, then he gave a comfortable portion to his kinsfolk, ‘and kept free for himself at his own disposal what was left, a great and fair estate. And then he declared that he wished to choose Christ and his saints as heirs of all that was left, and that he wished to raise up a seat for canons in Thick-by. Howbeit this matter was hard to put into effect at first, wherefore he sought at first to get hold of that which was the hardest to get — a man that might establish the rule which they, that wished to turn to a pure life there, were to keep. And now he went to Kirk-by and called on Thor-lac to undertake

it. And he was not very hard to persuade, because he had already had it in his heart to put off the world and come under rule [i.e., be canon or monk], according to the words of Almighty God when he declareth that ‘no man can be wholly his disciple save he forsake all that he hath for God’s sake, and serveth him afterward with a pure heart’ [Matt xix. 21]. Nevertheless he opened the matter to Bearn-hedin the priest, asking him how he looked on it, or what appeared to him best to do, whether he should consent to take up the office to which he was called. But Beam-hedin said that it would be a heavy day for him when Thor-lac left Kirk-by; but yet he said that he could not find it in him to hinder him much therefrom, because he saw that the salvation of many folk hung upon it. And so there was an endowment made at Thick-by by the counsel and advice of bishop Clong and all the men of the hundred, and Thor-lac moved thither, and there was established a House of Canons [regular].

19

2. But that day when Thor-lac went forth at the last out of Kirk-by, the whole of the people accompanied him out of the garth, and they felt it grievously to part with him. And when Bearn-hedin came home again, entering the hall, he looked at Thor-lac’s seat, and spake with great earnestness, saying, that that was a seat that would never be so well filled again unless he himself sat there again. And it was Thor-lac’s wont to say all his life after, which was a great credit to the estate and to them that held it, that he had never been so happy before as he was those six winters he was at Kirk-by. Many great commendations have fallen to this place, but this was the greatest, for it may most likely be believed that that must have been a good place above others which he esteemed the best.

20

3. Thor-lac was full thirty-five years old [1168] when he moved to Wer, and there he was seven winters. He first took the orders of a canon, and then was the first prior set over the canons that were there, and he; ordered their life so fairly, that it was the verdict of wise men that

they had nowhere seen such a good way of life, where there had been a regular [canonical] life established, so short a time as there.

21

4. And after that bishop Clong hallowed Thor-lac as abbot of Wer, and then he began afresh to rule in a wonderful way over the brethren whom he was set over. He bade them to maintain love and unity among themselves, and laid before them how great gain there was therein, seeing what the Son of God saith that 'wheresoever two or three should be gathered in His name, he would be in the midst of them' [Matt, xviii. 20]. Above all he was most zealous on their behalf, and they were well cared for in every way.

22

5. Halla, Thor-lac's mother, was with him all his life, as long as she was alive, but he had given both his sisters their portions before he entered upon the regular life. He was loving to all his kinsfolk afterward as before, and a ghostly father to all them that he was set over. He forbade the brethren roaming abroad, and every journey for which there was no necessity, and bade them to be steadfast in good works at their duties, according to the teaching of the apostle Paul in his epistle [1 Thess v. 17, 18], 'Pray without ceasing,' saith he, 'and give God thanks in all things.' Moreover the Son of God himself saith, 'Holpen is he that is steadfast in good deeds even unto the end of his life' [Matt xxiv. 13]. He bade them to keep strict silence, when it was required, but to hold good conversation when speech was allowed them, for according to the words of the apostle Paul, 'Evil communications,' saith he, 'corrupt good manners' [1 Cor xv. 33]. And it must be manifest how needful it is in this [course of] life to keep oneself from worldly and wicked words, if it even be wrong to speak good words when it is enjoined that there be silence, as David saith in the Psalter [Ps vulg xxxviii. 3], 'I am lowly,' saith he, 'and I kept silence even in a good matter.' He thought himself a lowly man because he was ever more ready to speak good than evil, but yet he often refrained from both for God's sake.

23

6. Men used to go to this house of Canons of abbot Thor-lac from other minsters and houses of regulars, both men of this land and aliens, to see and copy the good customs there, and every one that went there bore witness that they had never been to any place where there was such a fair life led as there according to the ordinances of Thor-lac. And then for the first time many men perceived that there was great good to be looked for where he was by reason of his holy life, beyond what could be worked by other men. Many men went away whole from his presence when he had given them his blessing and chanted over them, that had come with divers ailments to him.

24

7. Many things also took place about him, which many men at once took to be miracles. This thing came to pass when he was at... to wit, that fire broke out in the house, but as soon as Thor-lac came up and blessed it the fire was quenched. If any live stock fell sick, they always began to mend as soon as he had chanted over them, if there were any life in them. His hallowing of water was mark-worthy insomuch that both men and cattle gat amendment [of their ills] thereby. If water, that Thor-lac had hallowed, was sprinkled over cattle, then well-nigh never did they take harm by sickness, or weather, or wild beasts. If mice were doing any harm to meat or clothes, there would arise a plague among them, or they would all disappear before the water if it were sprinkled about, and if all were done as he gave orders. This holy water soon got to be taken about over all the neighbourhood, and, after Thor-lac was bishop, over all Iceland, for everywhere men thought that they could perceive they got good thereby in that wherein they were in most need. Nevertheless wise men walked warily with regard to those things, whether it were in calling these things plain miracles or in interpreting it as [proceeding from] his particular sanctity, for so saith Holy Writ, 'Thou shalt not praise a man in his lifetime, praise him after his life and magnify him according to the reward of his life' [cp. Eccl iv. 2], and this was spoken to this end, that it may lead to assurance, both in them that speak before the end of a

man's life is known to the full, and it may also be that such speech may entice the heart of the man himself into something of pride. And it is now made manifest how well it hath turned out that men followed these wholesome admonitions in this case, namely, in there being few that praised him overmuch in his life. But now do ye praise and make much of him in every way that ye be able, for ye know his worth and his saintliness!

25

7. 1. Now when the behaviour and life of the holy Thor-lac was shining with such bloom of purity and goodness of life, and seemly prudence with regard to the lives of others as hath but now been told, Almighty God began to prepare the way for that which he already intended, namely, that his honour might be strengthened and increase beyond what it then was. And it came about in this way —

26

2. When bishop Clong was getting far stricken in years, he took a great illness, so that his feet broke out into sores, and he became very unable to do his office by reason of his illness. And he had already gotten leave of archbishop Ey-stan for this, to have a man chosen to be bishop after him. Wherefore bishop Clong went to the All-moot and required of his friends that a man should be chosen to go abroad [to be hallowed bishop], and meetings were appointed therefore. That same summer, as if he had been sent thither by God, abbot Thor-lac came to the All-moot upon some business which he thought needful to do there, for he was never wont to leave home save it were for some business that heeded it. When the discourse began about this matter, there were three more named for choice to be made from, who were thought to be best fitted therefore of all men. And one of them was abbot Thor-lac; the second abbot was named Ogmund, a paragon of men. The third was a priest named Paul, a man of great learning and a very great householder. There was fair testimony borne to each of them, and every one was most eager that he whom he happened to know best should be chosen. But this was made known in Thor-lac's case that he

had not puffed himself up with that pride that is called self-conceit, and that he showed forth his good works in the face of God rather than of men, and strove rather to be better than other men in righteousness than merely to seem so before the eyes of foolish men. And therefore it was, that to many he seemed to be the least known of those which the choice was to be made from. And this was to be excused, because he had not been a very near neighbour to many folk as far as his country and his dwelling-place went. Thor-lac was of few words at these meetings, but many others, who had much less to do with the matter than he, were wordy enough. It was inquired of Thor-kel Geireson, who was well approved for his truthfulness, and who of all wise and noble men was best acquainted with Thor-lac, what were Thor-lac's gifts, and whether he was a good speaker. But Thor-kel answered, 'Thor-lac takes pains rather to do best than speak most.' This answer was to men's liking, and many straightway began to favour Thor-lac the more heartily, when they heard such worthy witness borne to his qualities by such a wise man and one of such judgment. The end of the matter was, that the choice was given to bishop Clong to choose one of them that had been picked out: and he chose Thor-lac to go out and to take his bishopric after him, and all the duties that appertained thereto. On Peter's mass- day [June 29, 1174] bishop Clong chose Thor-lac to be bishop, and he wished straightway to hand over to him all the governance of the estates. But when the choice had fallen upon the holy abbot Thor-lac, he said that it had come upon him unawares, and declared that he had not refused to be one of them picked out, but other men whom he declared to be best fitted to the office might have less inducement to excuse themselves [from standing]. He excused himself much, and said that he himself was not at all well fitted to this office and dignity. But he could say nought that availed against the appeal and eagerness of the people, and all the more as he suspected even then that it was God's will, as indeed afterwards it proved to be, wherefore he at last consented to the choice that was made.

3. The lord abbot Thor-lac went back from the Moot to his house of Canons, and prayed bishop Clong that he would keep the governance of the see and of the estate till the next season or the winter over. And at that time the estate at Seal-holt began to be in a bad way, for the outgoings were great and the income small, and the bishop was unable to go on his visitations, wherefore all fees ceased, and it could not go on to the end of the year without the need of some greater supply [than was in store].

28

4. After Yule men were sent from Seal-holt to fetch the bishop-elect, and he started from the east at Lent, and with him John Loft's son, who was in those days the greatest chief in Iceland; and they came to the estate at Seal-holt half a month before Easter [1175], and Gizor Hall's son was already there. There were also other men there who were the friends of the bishop, and the chief men of the country-side. Then Thor-lac took up the governance of the estate, and there was straightway a great debt run up for those things that there was need of which the place required. And he had forthwith great trials [to undergo], both in dealings with them that were there, and other unpleasantnesses which he had to put up with, but he bore them all patiently.

29

5. Bishop Clong lay in bed very weak, and Thor-lac abode at Seal-holt, because men would not let him go abroad by reason of the broken peace that was at that time between Norway and Iceland, for there were cases unsettled which had arisen between the two lands by reason of manslaughters and robberies, wherefore he remained for certain winters. But when bishop Clong was dead [Feb. 28, 1176], it came to this, that he thought it needful that there should be no longer the lack of a bishop in Seal-holt, as it was now. Then he would not let his journey be stayed any longer. And it was of no avail though he were dissuaded from his journey by reason of the broken peace. He took example by the word of Paul the apostle, 'Ye shall not be afraid for the

threatening of the wicked,' said he [cp. Heb xiii. 6]. And after this he made ready, but would take but little money with him in comparison with what others had taken before him, and no great following, and he had a fair voyage until they came to Norway.

30

8. 1. WHEN Thor-lac the bishop-elect came to archbishop Ey-stan, he received him wonderfully well, and soon let it be known that he would cheerfully do all on his part that he thought needful, save that he would not give him the office of bishop without he got the king's consent. A father and son at that time held rule over Norway — king Magnus and earl Erling his father — and they entertained Thor-lac's case very unwillingly, and from this quarter there came angry words rather than easement to the end that neither men nor goods should be untouched [i.e.. that an embargo should be laid on Thor-lac and his men, and they themselves attached]. But Thor-lac made light of this, and showed that all his heart was there, as [David] teacheth in the Psalter [Ps vulg cxvii. 8], 'It is better to trust in the Lord than in princes,' wherefore he let the matter pass by him. But the archbishop felt himself to be in great jeopardy, for he wished to love both, and he also wished to observe that which Peter the apostle teacheth in his epistle: 'Fear God,' saith he, 'and honour the king' [1 Peter ii. 17].

31

And it was made manifest throughout that he wished to satisfy both in this matter, and now the archbishop mediated between them and other men of good will; and it came about that the king and the earl consented that Thor-lac should take bishop's orders, and there was brought about a show of friendship between them, and they gave each other gifts before they parted. And king Swerre hath oftentimes said, who was both a man of weighty speech and of wise judgment, that all things went smoothly for that father and son both in battle and well-nigh all else, when there was friendship between them, and Thor-lac was out there in Norway. a. Thor-lac was hallowed bishop by archbishop Ey-stan in the days of pope Alexander [III], three nights

after the passion of the apostles Peter and Paul [July 2, 1178]. There was present at the consecration Eiric, bishop of Staf-anger, who was afterwards archbishop in Thron-d ham, after archbishop Ey-stan. The third [including the archbishop] that was present at the consecration of bishop Thor-lac was Paul, bishop of Bergen, a paragon of men, and a friend of bishop Thor-lac all his life after. Bishop Thor-lac was but a short while with the archbishop after he had received consecration, because he knew very well what desire there was for his return to Iceland to the sheep over whom he had been appointed [pastor].

32

3. And when bishop Thor-lac had departed from the presence of the archbishop, the other bishops that were with him asked him what he thought of bishop Thor-lac. He said that he thought he had never consecrated a bishop whom he thought his peer in all the qualities that a bishop ought to have, as the apostle Paul saith in his epistle which he sent to Titus: 'A bishop should be,' saith he, 'blameless and of good learning, of simple life and no drunkard, a free giver and not greedy, sage and sober, a lover of good and given to hospitality, righteous in his life and of good report, a pure liver and prudent, trusty and truthful, open-handed and out-spoken, loving to all men but a rebuker to transgressors' [Tit. 1. 7, 8], And it is manifest that to have these gifts is the mark of a holy man. 'And I cannot show you better how wise his ways have appeared to me,' said the archbishop, 'than by saying that I would like to live my last day as I see him live every day.' And thereby it is manifest how wise and clear-sighted he must have been by this opinion of his about the beloved bishop Thor-lac.

33

4. Bishop Thor-lac went down to take ship with his followers, and when they were well-nigh ready to sail the shipmen loaded the ship till she would hardly swim with the loose [deck] timber, and two boats that they lashed outside the bulwarks. Then the bishop went ashore out of the ship and told the shipmen that he thought she was overladen. Then answered one of them whose name was Macan, 'Thou

hast no share in the ship,' said he, 'and thou shalt not say how she shall be loaded.' The bishop answered, 'I forbid you in God's name,' said he, 'to load her to the sinking point, and I charge you with the lives of all them that journey with you.' Then the bishop went aboard again, and they put to sea with her as she was. And when they were come hard by Iceland there came up a great gale, and gat great damage, the halyard parted and the sail was carried away overboard. Nearly all of them were minded to make vows [for safety], but bishop Thor-lac said that they should not make vows till they had cast overboard some of their lading. And when it was cast overboard as the bishop wished, immediately the gale abated and they made land the next day, and bishop Thor-lac came home to Seal-holt [Aug. 9, 1178], the day before Lawrence-mass-day.

34

9. 1. MEN were very fain of his home-coming, and he straightway began to take up the quiet rule of those things that came before him with power and zeal. Nevertheless he kept closely to all the rules of the canonry that he could comply with now that he was become a bishop, both as to the fashion of his garments and in vigils and fasts and prayers. He began to order anew the ways of the household and customs of the house, which order of his endured all his days in many ways.

35

2. Bishop Thor-lac gave the most love and affection to those priests and clerks that lived soberly and kept their orders somewhat according to the rules thereof, and these he duly prized and established them fairly [i.e. gave them good livings] as far as the means [of the see] allowed. But those clerks that lived less soberly and observed their orders less carefully, he admonished them with kindly ordinances to do better, and turn their paths aright and the ways of those that they had to care for. But they that did not change for his gentle admonitions he rebuked with strong compulsions and gentle penances,

as the apostle Paul taught Timothy [2 Tim iv. 2]: 'Thou shalt admonish, exhort and rebuke, with all long-suffering and doctrine.'

36

3. He took great care of the estates of the see, and would ever make able men stewards, so that he might be the most free himself from those cares; but yet that the income of the estates might flourish according to what was possible, but yet so that all might be provided that there was need of. And he managed his income so wisely that all wise men straightway fell to saying how good was the order he kept in all matters.

37

4. But no matter how great care he gave to the ordering of all that touched his income so that all might go in the best way, yet he gave his best thought to all that touched the Church, and that the clergy should be chosen from among the best in all ways, and along with this he took care of the way that the clergy did all their services, and taught them lovingly all the duties that they were bound to fulfil according to their several orders.

38

5. He made a form of confession for the use of all the clergy in his diocese [Dipl. Isl. 1. p. 240], so that all might order it one way. And he bade all men go to shrift once every twelve-month at least; and all they that served at the altar, if they fell into any capital sin, he bade confess themselves every time before they touched God's service or sung mass.

39

6. He used to gather together the clergy home to him at Seal-holt at the great feasts, and then he would tell them what each man ought to do so that everything that each was bound to do should go fairly forward in God's sight. And the more zealous he was with regard to other men, yet ever he did best of all himself, so that every one could distinguish what he did from what all the rest of the clergy did, so finely did he prepare all the services in God's sight, so that it was a joy to see and give ear thereto.

40

7. Bishop Thor-lac often preached sermons, and this was a great trial to him, for he was slow and hindered of speech, but his words were so sweet and so well put together that it must needs come into the mind of them that listened to his sermons how David speaketh in the Psalter: 'O Lord, Thy words are sweeter in my throat than honey and than honeycomb in my mouth' [Ps cxix. 103]. These same words of God bishop Thor-lac put forth also in his life with such fair ensamples as that there could scarcely be found such goodly ones in the life of any man that was then alive.

41

8. Bishop Thor-lac would keep long vigils by night when other men slept, and he would pray fervently that he might inherit this which God spake: 'Blessed is that servant,' saith He, 'whom the Lord shall find watching when He cometh to visit him' [Matt xxiv. 46]. And that is also clearly spoken in the Word of God which He spake Himself:

42

'Watch ye,' saith He, 'for ye know not what hour your Lord cometh'

43

[Matt xxiv. 42]. And it hath been well proven that Thor-lac must have seldom had these words out of his mind, because that hath now come to him which God promised to them that were sober in watching, that 'He would set them over all good things' [Matt xxiv. 47] after this fife.

44

9. The holy bishop Thor-lac used much to fast when he was at home in his bishop's seat, remembering therein what the Lord Himself said in the Gospel, that there is a 'certain kind of devil that cannot be overcome save by prayer and fasting' [Matt xvii. 21], and therefore he conformed thereto in his life, wishing to overcome all the wiles of the devils.

45

10. He comforted them that were sorrowful, and held out to them that which the Lord Himself spake, 'Blessed are they that mourn now, for

they shall be comforted' [Matt v. 4]; and in another Gospel when He was speaking with His apostles, 'Your sorrow shall be turned into joy' [John xvi. 20].

46

11. The blessed bishop Thor-lac strove with all earnestness to bring together and make peace between those that were wroth and at enmity with one another, telling them as it was said and as it is true, that wrath blotteth out the righteousness of them she dwelleth with, as James the apostle saith, 'That the wrath of man worketh not the righteousness of God' [James i. 20]; and in another place [it is written], 'Be not overcome of evil, but rather overcome evil with good' [Rom xii. 21], that is to say,- wrath is to be overcome with long-suffering and kindness.

47

12. Bishop Thor-lac was often looking in holy books, and reading in holy writings, inasmuch as he forgot not that which the apostle John saith in his book [Rev xxii. 7], 'Blessed is he that readeth and heareth the words of these books, and keepeth those things that are written therein.' He would often be teaching clerks both to read books and learn what else was useful to them; he perceived how great need there was of good teaching, as David saith in the psalter [Ps lxvi. 16], 'Come hither, O my sons, and hearken unto me, and I will teach you how ye shall fear God.'

48

13. He was ever awriting, and always he would be reading holy books, according to the ensamples of the apostle Paul, as he saith in his epistle [2 Cor. 1. 13], 'We write none other things unto you than what ye have most need to read and know.'

49

14. And whatever else bishop Thor-lac had to do his lips were never silent from the praise of God or from prayer, because he kept in mind what the apostle James saith in his epistle [James v. 16], 'The effectual fervent prayer of a righteous man availeth much with God,' and his

prayer hath stood in good stead or availed much both to himself and many others. The bishop was gentle and meek in all his ordinances, and of wholesome counsel in every matter that he was sought to for: and he hath now entered into that estate which God hath promised them that are that way disposed, where He speaketh in the Gospel, ‘Blessed are the meek, for they shall inherit the everlasting land of the living’ [Matt v. 5].

50

15. Bishop Thor-lac sang mass every day both to his own and other men’s salvation, remembering continually the passion of the Son of God, and he hath now thereby received for his service the more fair reward according as he was more frequent and noteworthy in that office than most other men.

51

16. He applied himself greatly to the cherishing of the poor; he used to clothe the cold and feed the hungry, whereby it was easy to see that that never went out of his mind, which is to be looked for on the last day, *namely*, how much it is declared to weigh in the scales what a man shall have done for the poor in this life. And he did this over and above what other good men had done before him, in that he would have poor folk called together at the greatest feasts, twelve or nine, or seven or five, and would go in secretly where they were and wash their feet, and wipe them with his hair, and give each of them some good alms ere he went away. And this he did rather after the example of God than of men, for He washed the feet of His apostles, and afterwards let Himself suffer for the salvation of all mankind. Moreover the Son of God spake thus when He had washed His apostles’ feet, ‘Do ye after my ensample as I now do to you’ [John xiii. 15]. Wherefore the blessed bishop Thor-lac let the washing of feet go before the gift of charity or mercy.

52

17. Nor could his dear friends and trusty men keep silence after his departure over a matter they felt they knew of a certain — to that he had a kind of secret penance and work of charity, the knowledge of

which he did not trust to any one, as God commandeth, that the \* left hand should not know what the right hand doeth' [Matt vi. 3]. And the bishop's dear friends dared not afterward to make that more known which he himself wished to be left so hidden or secret.

53

10. 1. BISHOP Thor-lac was wont often to have speech with good men and them of a righteous life, to make acquaintance with their ways thereby and strengthen them by his wholesome admonitions, that they might stand fast in their well-doing. He also kept strict watch over the deeds of those men that did not beware of their own sins, in order to lead them back from wrong paths, and call them back into right paths, though they had gone amiss before, according as the Lord spake, 'I will not the death of a sinner, but rather that he should turn to me and live' [Ez xviii. 32]. This the blessed bishop Thor-lac showed to all that would repent of their faults, and if they would follow his advice, he was then rejoiced, and showed mercy to them with light penances, according as the prophet of God said, 'That whatever day a man will turn to God that he should then live a good life and die no ill death' [Ez xxxiii. 11]. But they that would not turn to the right way by his kindly upbraiding, and not forsake their dangerous condition at his rebuke, then he would interdict some, and excommunicate others, according as Christ bade His disciples: 'Ye shall rebuke your brother lovingly,' and 'if he neglect to hear thee, let him be to thee as a heretic or a heathen' [Matt, xviii. 15, 17]. He bore patiently the evil deeds of men, but he grieved greatly at their evil condition, and never consented to the evil conversation of wicked men, though he was quick to hearken to what God speaketh: 'Blessed are they that suffer patiently, for they shall be called the sons of God' [Matt v. 9]. He suffered at men's disobedience, because he wept at the ghostly wounds of them that were under his charge, as was the way with the apostle Paul with regard to God's Christendom in his days, that 'no man suffered or was afflicted,' but he felt in himself, 'in his own body those sufferings by reason of the love he bore them' [2 Cor. 1. 6, *paraph.*].

54

2. The holy bishop Thor-lac so used the authority that was given to him when he was consecrated, to bind and loose on God's behalf the condition of men, that it seemed to wise and righteous men as if there was equal care taken on the one side, that there should be no passion or lack of moderation, yet on the other, that he was never so slack or lenient, though it were a difficult matter to deal with, that it did not savour rather of meekness and mercy, though he were to wait a long time, if it were rightly considered. He let it often come into his mind what David saith, that the 'Lord loveth mercy and righteousness, and showeth forth glory and loving-kindness' [Ps lxxxvi. 5].

55

3. This is also to be recorded, that bishop Thor-lac loved that place most after Seal-holt which he had adorned with his presence [i.e.. Thick-by], He hallowed as abbot of Wer, God-mund the son of Bialfe, a good man and righteous, open-handed and void of pride. Thor-kell Gar's son that was spoken of before in this story, went thither under the rule thereof, and kept it well as long as he lived, and died in the ninth year of the bishopric of bishop Thor-lac.

56

4. In the days of bishop Thor-lac it was made law to keep holy Ambrose-day, and Cecil's-day, and Agnes-day; and to fast the vigils of the Apostles' masses, and Nicholas-mass. He strictly ordered the Friday fast to be kept in such wise that there should be two meals eaten on no ordinary Friday, save the one that is in Easter-wreek. He kept Friday so strictly himself that he ate nothing solid if he were well; but he was so lenient and easy in this when he was sick that he would eat white meat on Ember-days and Fridays if he were asked to do so, and these ensamples he gave to men who now would act just so as they hope may seem best in God's eyes. Bishop Thor-lac was sick while he was bishop on a time when Yule-day fell on Friday [1181, 1187 or 1192], and he was in weak health, and he used flesh that day, and showed an example therein that it were better so to do.

57

5. He took great pains to keep those folks together that were bound in holy wedlock, and laid heavy penalties in fines and shrifts upon them that had made grievous breaches therein. For he thought that it was the greatest offence to God if that indulgence which is the greatest worldly thing He hath given to man, and which He hath made, for His loving-kindness' sake and out of mercy and by reason of the lusts of men, lawful and blessed, which indeed otherwise were a capital sin — if this indulgence were monstrously disgraced and wrongly abused. And the moneys which some paid for their sin he would never mix with other money, but set them apart, that those households which lived well together but were poor might be enabled thereby to continue in the same [rather than be parted by poverty], and he would that this might be some further amends and compensation for their faults who had paid their moneys.

58

6. In his day, bishop Thor-lac broke all those connections which he knew to have been unlawfully made, whether those that had part therein were great or small. He was not able to live in all communion with some [great] men and chiefs, because he would only consent to the doings of those that were right and good. He thought it were a far greater destruction to God's Christendom if gentle-folks were to be excused in great matters, and he would not show them any more indulgence, when they did not keep themselves from unlawful dealings in this kind, because they had received from God a greater portion of wealth and honour.

59

11. 1. Now it is to be told of the every-day habits of the blessed Thor-lac how temperate he was in all good courses. He never spoke a word that did not tend to some good purpose when he was asked anything. He was so wary of his words that he never blamed the weather as many do, or any of those things that are not blameworthy, but which he perceived went according to God's will. He did not look forward to any

day above the rest, nor did he dread any one much, save it were the All-moot and Ember-days — the All-moot, because he thought that many a man went astray in the cases he had there, even a man of great worship in a matter which he had at heart, or thought of great import; and the Ember-days, because he thought it a great responsibility to consecrate men who had come a long way therefore, but whom he saw to be very poorly fitted therefore, both by reason of their small learning and other conditions not to his liking. Nevertheless he could not find heart to refuse them, both because of their own poverty, and for the sake of them that had presented them or sent their tokens withal; wherefore he would tell every man piece by piece what duty appertained to each order, and handed over the responsibility in the matter to themselves and them that had sent them to be ordained.

60

2. He was so regular in his fasts when he was at home, and in vigils and prayers whether he were at home or not, that it was always to be guessed what he would be doing. He used so little food that one could not but think that he would often put away his food when he had the most desire for it. His way with regard to drink was that one could never see it to have any hold over him, even though he partook of strong drink. But he had such luck with regard to [the brewing of] drink when he was entertaining his friends, that the ale never went bad when he blessed it and made the cross over it with his hand, when it was about to work. He was easy to satisfy and so friendly at feasts when there was drinking that he put up with any kind of drink, no matter how poor if it was not quite bad. But whenever bishop Thor-lac drank water or other harmless drink, he did it so soberly and with such restraint that he would sip three sips of it or five or seven, and well-nigh never more. Moreover he well-nigh never drank between meals when he was not ill, and there was not a public drinking-feast.

61

3. Bishop Thor-lac was never quite hale during the whole of his bishopric, and this was to be looked for according as Paul the apostle

saith, that ‘the strength is made perfect out of sickness’ [2 Cor xii. 9]. He would let the doctors often perform operations upon him for his ailment, and showed that God had ordained leeches that they might at times by the Lord’s will stop long ills by short pains.

62

4. Bishop Thor-lac kept regular habits in his prayers beyond that of most other men. He used to sing first the *Credo* and the *Pater Noster*, after he had crossed himself, and the hymn *Jesu Nostra Redemptio*, and thereby showed forth straightway that he was ever thinking of that salvation by which God hath ransomed mankind and [set] true love between God and men, the desire of everlasting bliss and presence with God, the dread of the judgment-day, and the coining of the Maker to judge all mankind — all which is proclaimed in this hymn. Then he would sing the Prayer of Gregory while he clad himself, and afterwards the first psalm out of the Psalter, for he never let those wholesome admonitions go out of his head which stands in this psalm: ‘Blessed is he that walketh not after them that be of evil counsel and consenteth not to the evil doing of sinners, and judgeth not wrong judgments, but ever observeth the laws of God’ [Ps. 1. 1, 2]. And when he came to church, he first sung the praise of the Holy Trinity, and afterward he would praise with song those saints to whom the church was hallowed, which he then happened to be in, and whose holy relics were kept there. Then he would read the *Hours of Mary*, and after that he would fall on his face on the ground before the altar, when it was not a holiday, and pray long for the whole Church of God. And every day he sung the third part of the Psalter, beside the chants for the day, whether he were at home or not. And he used to sing more [doxology] between the psalms than other men, for he used first to sing *Gloria Patri* to the Holy Trinity, and next *Miserere mei Deus*, and then *Salvum fac Pater et Domine* for all Christian people. But if there came a difficult case before him, he used to sing the verse wherewith Solomon the wise man prayed to God in his days, *Mitte mihi, Domine, auxilium de Sancto*, and when he went forth from the table he used to sing *Benedicam*

*Dominum in omni tempore*; and when he took off his clothes to sleep he sang the psalm wherein the Lord is put in remembrance of His promise that they shall be without fear that keep His counsels righteously, and hurt others neither in word nor work. This psalm is, *Domine, quis habitabit* [Ps xiv], and it was a great joy to him to keep such customs, for he thought that some one might perchance follow after his habit therein.

63

5. He took pleasure in stories, and poems, and all songs and lays, and wise men's conversation and dreams, and all that good men took pleasure in, save plays, because he thought that such things kept men away from the unprofitable ways of wicked men [wherefore he was beloved by all that were about him].

64

6. Bishop Thor-lac dreamed this dream at the All-moot: he thought he was walking from the church there at the Moot to his booth carrying the head of St. Martin in his arms, but Paul the priest of Reek-holt, a man of worth, read his dream so, that he himself would afterwards bear a holy bishop's head wherever he went, and it is now manifest to all that this is true.

65

12. 1. WHEN bishop Thor-lac had been fifteen winters in his see of Seal-holt in the office of a bishop, in the bright bloom of good works, beloved by God and by good men, [but] much wearied by his adversaries and also by manifold ailments, then he declared secretly to certain of them whom he trusted that he was minded to give up the bishopric, saying, that they needed to get a stronger ox under the yoke which he had been set under hitherto, and he himself wished to go back to his house of Canons with lowliness, and serve God and the saints there as long as he lived.

66

But Almighty God, who had raised him up to the highest place of clerkly office, saw that he might yet be worthy of a glorious reward,

even though his honour was not lessened in men's eyes, wherefore he would not let this come about, but rather prepared for him such a holy preparation for death as every wise man would chose for himself and his dearest friends.

67

2. Bishop Thor-lac went for the last time round that Quarter which lay nearest to him; and in Borg-frith there came upon him the sickness that brought him to his grave. He came home to the seat of his see with but small strength, and lay abed three months with a troublesome illness all the while, but never great pain; and he was able to pay heed to all things that were of most import to himself and others as well as if he had been a hale man.

68

There was then staying at Seal-holt Gizor Hall's son, who was both a wise man and kindly. He came often to see the bishop in his weakness, and strengthened him with many fair histories, both interesting and rare, of the saints, or other good men that had borne their afflictions best in their trials. There came there also many of his friends and kinsmen to see him, and get good counsel from him, and show him their true love with all their heart. Paul, his sister's son, came to him in his sickness, showing then as before that he was the most loving of all his noble kinsmen.

69

3. But when the sickness of bishop Thor-lac began to grow greatly upon him, he sent to fetch Thor-wald the son of Gizor Hall's son, who had both understanding and knowledge in great store, and was ever deemed well fitted to have the direction or decision of all matters of weight. And when he was come, the bishop gave him a careful account of the whole state of the lands and properties of the see, both how it had stood when he came to it, and what was the state it had now reached when he believed that he could manage it no longer. He also counted over to him particularly those outlays which he had spent upon his kinsmen since he came to the management of the estate, and

how he had brought them into a thriving state, no matter how much they had lacked. But when they saw that the estates had become much easier to manage and much wealthier in revenue, and that there had been great lack of money in them that were near-of-kin to him, then, by the counsel of Thor-wald and his other friends, he endowed his kinsmen yet again with certain outlays.

70

4. He declared that he wished to give his raiment to the clergy, and the richest he gave to the bishop that should come after him, but he would not give any indication as to whom he should be. His other raiment he gave to priests and other clerks, and the worst to the poof, for he would never leave them out when he was sharing gifts among his friends: and it was a joy to him then that he had given many hundreds [of money or cloth] and many ship-pounds or weights of meat to them every season.

71

To bishop Brand of Holar he gave a finger-ring, but the ring he himself had borne daily on his hand he gave to Paul his sister's son, that was bishop next after him, and it was his consecrated ring, and many took it as a sign or token of the honour that afterwards came upon him. And this blessing was forthwith manifest, which is now not wondered at, so that every man deemed he got some good that got some remembrance that had once belonged to him.

72

5. Bishop Thor-lac went over particularly all private business with Thor-wald before they parted, which he thought most necessary for him to know; some he kept secret, others to be disclosed after his death.

73

6. Seven nights before he died, the bishop called together the clergy and had himself anointed; and before he got the unction he made a very long speech, though speech was slow and hard to him. 'When I lay abed before,' said he, 'with little strength and received unction in that

sickness also, and when the chaunt [of the service for the dying] was to be performed as it is now, then I declared beforehand that all those men that were under grave charges before me should be free of his sentence if I were to be taken away. And this I meant as an act of mercy, but not as a condemnation of what I myself had done. But the reward I got therefore was that those, who would not treat my intent fairly, said that they could see that I had felt in my mind that I had gone farther in my sentences than I should, and that I was wishing to mitigate them altogether after my life was gone. But now I will give a proof [and show] whether these things have been true. Ye shall now hearken to and declare my sentence — that I will that all my sentences stand and the declarations of excommunication, unless they [that are under them] be reconciled to those men whom I have appointed to loose my laws, and I hold forth no absolution other than that which I have laid down before, and if not they must wait for the bishop that is to come after me.'

74

7. And when he had said this, then he rested first, and afterwards he spoke to them that stood by: 'I wish to pray you,' said he, 'that ye forgive me whatsoever I have done that ye have not thought right.' All they that were by answered that they knew of no such thing, but yet that they would willingly grant him what he had asked of them. Then Gizor Hall's son spake on behalf of all, for he was the best fitted in every way: 'We pray you, my lord, to forgive us that which we have misspoken or misdome towards you, and we are afraid that it is both much and great.' And the blessed bishop Thor-lac consented cheerfully thereto. Then Gizor made a second speech, and it is now manifest that the Holy Ghost was speaking through him: 'We pray you this, my lord, although ye seem now to be parting with us as far as the bodily presence, that ye be a ghostly father to us and an intercessor for mercy with Almighty God, for we believe this, that ye will have no less power in the spiritual life with God than ye have now.' But he was silent and answered nothing, and it is manifest why he did so, because now he

granteth all that which he was then asked to do, but he would not then make it apparent, by reason of his lowliness, that he could think that he would be able to do this. And in this he behaved after the ensample of the Son of God, when he gave assent by holding his peace to certain things that were true, as the saints say [in the Gospels]. But when they had spoken thus, they that stood by were so overcome that there were few but could refrain from weeping.

75

8. But when the lord bishop saw that, he spake, 'Do not take it sore, though our lives must part. I have been a man of small account in every way, and little able to do' aught if other men had not upheld me, wherefore ye have small loss in me, and I am going as it is appointed to me, but he shall come after me that shall be a man of great account. Moreover I will give you this comfort, that I am in [good] hope that God will not condemn me as one of the damned.' Then he kissed all his clerks and the rest of them that were in his household, and gave them all his blessing. After this he received the last unction, and after that he would say nought but what he deemed most needful, but ever as long as he could his lips moved in prayer as long as he was alive.

76

9. When seven nights were passed from the time when the blessed bishop Thor-lac was anointed, he asked early in the day that his clothes might be changed. Then Orm Eyj-olf's son the priest, his chaplain, went to him and said, 'We think it dangerous to move you, my lord, so weak as ye be, and will ye not keep your clothes in case ye have no long life?' The bishop answered: 'It will do no harm to move me, and as to the unction I put my trust, in God's mercy and not in these clothes.' Then other clothes were given him, and there came no harm, as he had told them [there would not]. That day men did not see that he had lost so much strength as [he] was afterwards shown [to have done], because he kept up all those same goodly ways as he had maintained before, though his strength was small, yet his heart was as steadfast as before. But when the day wore on somewhat toward

evening, then it began to go more hardly with him; and when evensong was finished, then they thought that he was fallen into a kind of swoon, but when he opened his eyes he said, 'Whither didst thou go then, Thor-kel?' And Gizor Hall's son took it that Thor-kel had appeared unto the bishop at his death, because he had been the man that had most certainly snatched him from jeopardy [of a worldly life].

77

10. And when bishop Thor-lac was come to his death, he asked them to give him to drink, and when he wished to turn to take it, he sunk back on his pillow and fell asleep sweetly with God; and God gave him this glory, that he should thirst at his death as God's own son had done, and the thirst of neither of them was slaked save in that everlasting life which the sons of God are ever thirsting after. God let this be made manifest in the death of the blessed bishop Thor-lac, that He should fulfil what He spake by the mouth of David [Ps vulg cxv. 15], \* Precious in the eyes of the Lord is the death of His saints.' And albeit it was at that time hidden from men that the state of the bishop was such as it is now known to be, yet men did not deem it so to be with him as it was with other dead men, but rather most men deemed it better to be with his dead body than it was to be with other men alive.

78

13. 1. THOSE things took place after the death of bishop Thor-lac that seemed of great import to them that were present and saw them, but they told them to few men at first, because they hoped that God would manifest more clearly what then was shown to them. This was one thing, that his colour was much brighter and more pleasant than that of other dead men. Another was, that the pupils of his eyes were bright a long time after his death as in a living man that can see. The third thing was, that there were many sores on his skin both small and great, but they were all healed when they were looked for, and they that saw it thought it even then of great import, but now no man wondereth that it was so. There was a cloth laid over his face, but when Gizor came he said, 'Let us see our father!' And the cloth was

then taken away. And when he looked at his face, he deemed it of more account the pleasure that it gave him to behold it, inasmuch as he was a man that knew best the meaning thereof. After this the corpse of bishop Thor-lac was laid out carefully and his hair cut, and men got great advantage from this relic.

79

2. He died the fifth day of the week [Thursday, Dec. 23], rather late in the day, one night before the preparation for Yule. He was then sixty years of age, and had been bishop fifteen winters. There were then passed from the birth of our Lord Jesus Christ mclxxx and vi winters [a thousand and a hundred and ninety and three years according to the reckoning of Dionysius] [1193].

80

14. 1. ON the morrow after, the corpse of bishop Thor-lac was carried to church and set up in the choir two nights to await the burial, and the second day of Yule it was laid in the earth. There were present Paul the deacon, his kinsman, who was bishop after him, and all the clergy that were in the neighbourhood. There came thither also at the same time the body of a poor man whom the bishop had taken out of beggary and maintained till his death-day; he had been a leper, and God wished thereby to set forth this act of charity of his, which was one out of many that he did for God's sake in his life.

81

2. But before men went away from the burying of the blessed bishop Thor-lac, Gizor Hall's son spake a long and fair speech upon what had taken place there according as the manner is over the grave or at the burying of men of rank. And I will set down certain of the words which he spake, which have gone least out of my mind. He set forth to them first what a profitable man he had been both to the see and to people in the country. After that he spake thus: —

82

3. 'I have been here present several times when such things took place as have taken place here to-day. Five bishops have been laid down here

while I was standing by. First bishop Thor-lac Run-olfsson, then bishop Cetil, and then bishop Magnus, after that bishop Clong, but now bishop Thor-lac. I have also been used to speak some words when these things took place, as the custom is in other lands at the burying of men of rank: and the matter of discourse hath always been exceeding good, because they have all been the greatest men of mark in their bishopdoms. And it is good to remember this, that in our own judgment and in the report of our forbears respecting those bishops that have been here before our days and in our own days, that bishop was always judged the best by those whom he was best known to. And glorious men as they have all been, this is nevertheless peculiar to Thor-lac, that he prepared himself for the office of bishop far more carefully than all the rest. He kept himself in chastity all his life, and he manifestly led a spotless life all his days with lowliness and all kind of holiness. He was hallowed at once, when he was yet a child, to the lower orders, one after another, until he was *made* priest as soon as might be by reason of his age. And when he was priest, then he gave himself to Almighty God under a regular life, and then he was hallowed canon, and after that prior, and lastly abbot. Whereby may be seen how he was looked on by his superiors and the wisest men that were best able to judge beforehand *of men*, in that they hallowed him to all the orders that he could take, for he kept so well every degree of his ‘orders, that there was nought to be thought of but to go on giving him each new degree as long as there was any left.

83

‘But nevertheless we are witnesses that, by God’s mercy, his rank hath now at this last been most advanced, inasmuch as he hath been called from us into everlasting bliss and glory with God. And we who know so well many of his good ways can hardly conform to what is commanded, namely, to give express judgment upon no man’s life! Still we have so much confidence in his worth that I think few men have reason for hope, if he be not now in full bliss, inasmuch as we know

that he hath been most unlike all other men in the goodliness of his life.’

84

Many other wise words Gizor spake in his speech, but none that have better shown his foresight and good judgment than these which have just been told, and which have been proven true by experience.

85

15. 1. Many things happened during those fifteen winters when Thorlac was bishop in Seal-holt, with regard to the deaths of mighty men. There died then earl Erling [1179] and king Magnus [1184] his son, king Waldimar [1182], Henry king of the English [1189], earl Eiric [1190], archbishop Eystan [1188]. There was also a battle at Ila-fields [1180]...

86

2. These died of Icelanders — Beorn, abbot of Thwart-water; Cari, abbot [of Thing-ore, 1187]; Og-mund, abbot [of Holy-fell, drowned 1188]; Hall, abbot [of Thwart-water, 1190]; and many other clerks and men of worth both here in the country and in other places.